MARRIOTT BONVOY™

UX CASE STUDY

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ART-40639

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Overview

- **What is Marriott BONVOY?**

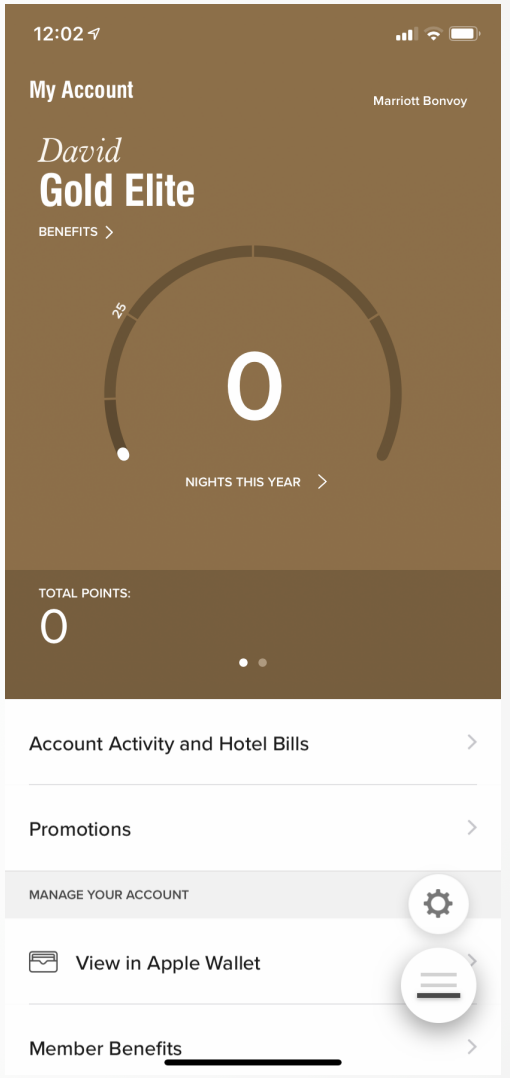
  Marriott BONVOY is the Marriott's group new rewards program. To accompany this new program a new mobile application was released for booking properties under the Marriott brand and to manage your Marriott rewards account. This allows you to see your current status as a member and how close you are to the next level as well as what benefits you get with your membership level.

- **This Case Study**

  This case study goes over the iOS application for the new rewards application. The new app tries some interesting design patterns that are a bit confusing on initial use. This study covers those findings and offers some recommended changes to improve the use of the application

PROBLEM – Top level navigation

- Navigation in the app is not intuitive compared to other applications. Since the app does not follow the standards/recommendations of the platform; in this case Apple iOS. Several sections have scrollable backgrounds and it seems that the circle at the bottom is for navigating that. However, this is not the case. That circle is the primary navigation between the main features of the application; booking, managing, rewards account. Even secondary circles appear to offer actions.

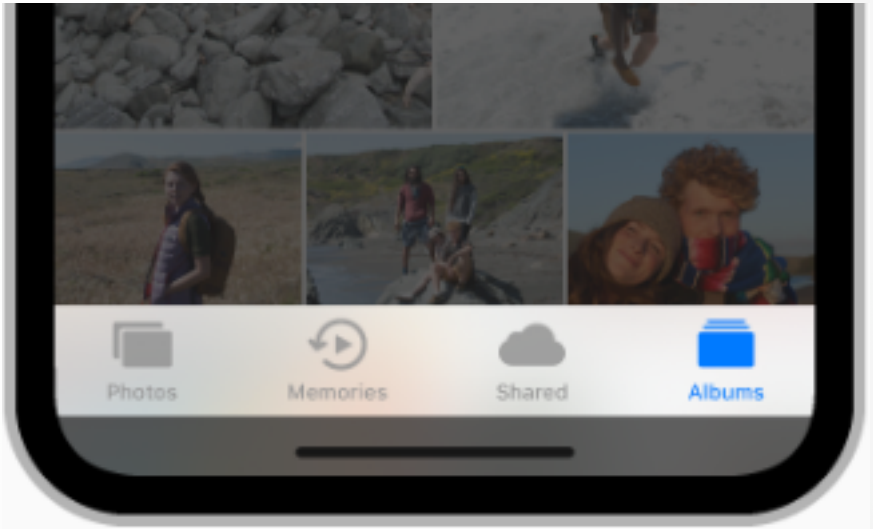


SOLUTION – Top level navigation

- Navigation is critical for successful use of an application. An app like this that offers a few distinct features can greatly benefit from the “Tab bar”. This tab bar can isolate flows into each tab. So one for Booking, My Trips, Membership, My Account. This is a perfect use case for tabs per Apple’s Human Interface Guidelines:

  “In general, use a tab bar to organize information at the app level. A tab bar is a good way to flatten your information hierarchy and provide access to several peer information categories or modes at once.”

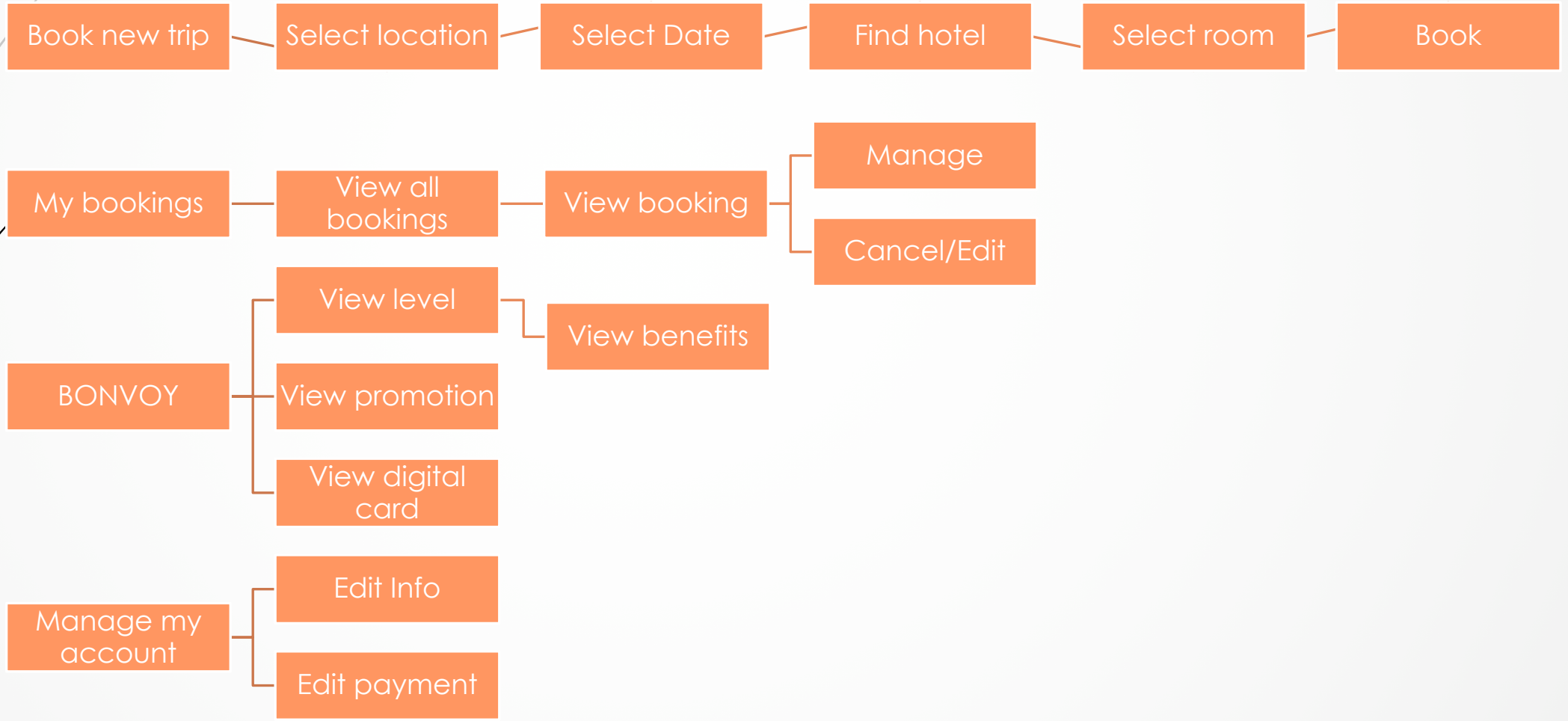
- This would allow the app to be isolated into each part that the user is most caring about and would avoid the need for any other mechanisms of navigating.
- This would also create a standardized approach to navigating on the iOS platform.



https://developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/ios/bars/tab-bars/

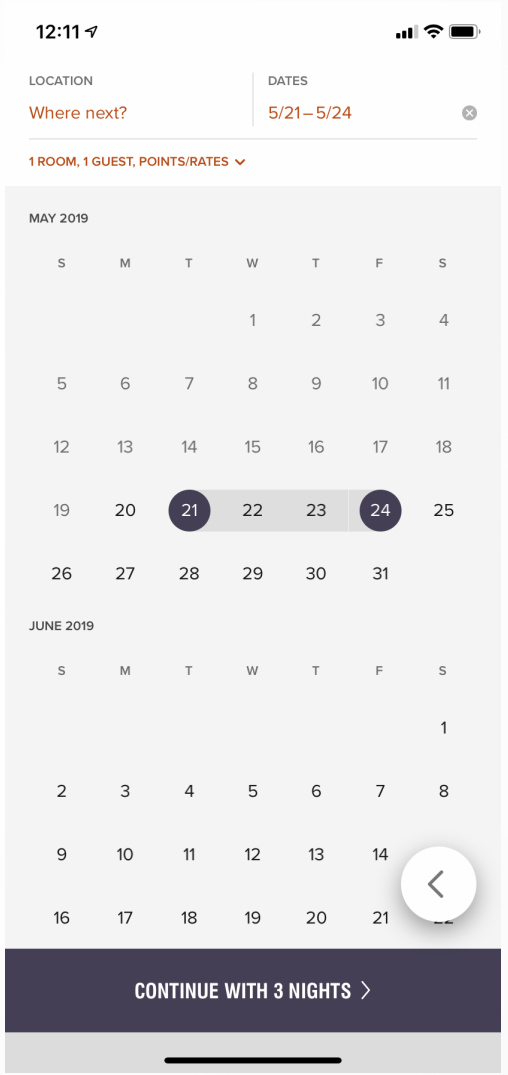
SOLUTION – Top level navigation

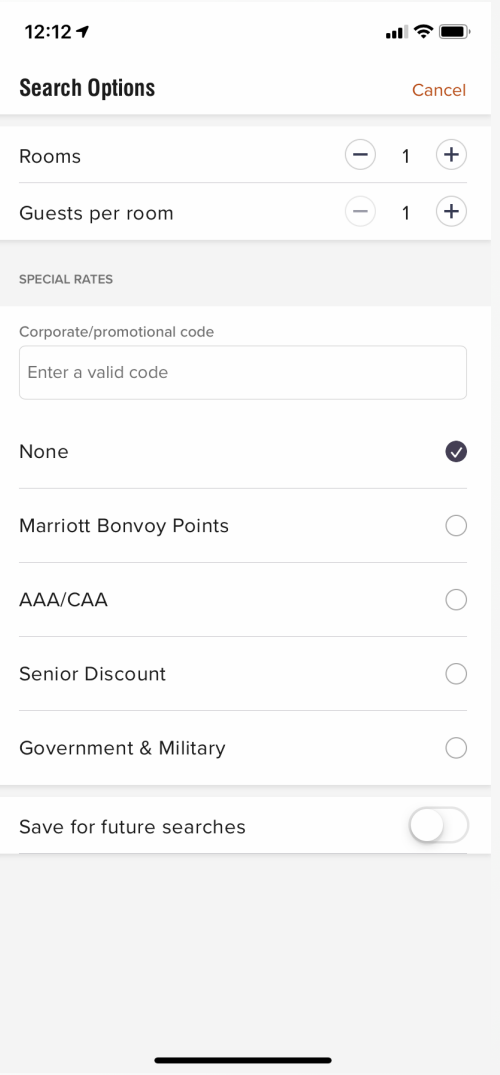
- This would introduce the following hierarchy of tabs:



PROBLEM – Booking Steps Enforcement

- From the home page the user can choose to enter booking via the ”Location” or ”Dates” selection box. However, the secondary page assumes an order of operation. And can get into an odd state when date is chosen first since the app implies results will be the next page.
- Secondary options like number of guests and rooms are hidden in a dropdown like option that implies a dropdown will appear to alter, but a new page is loaded which can break the flow of finding a booking.



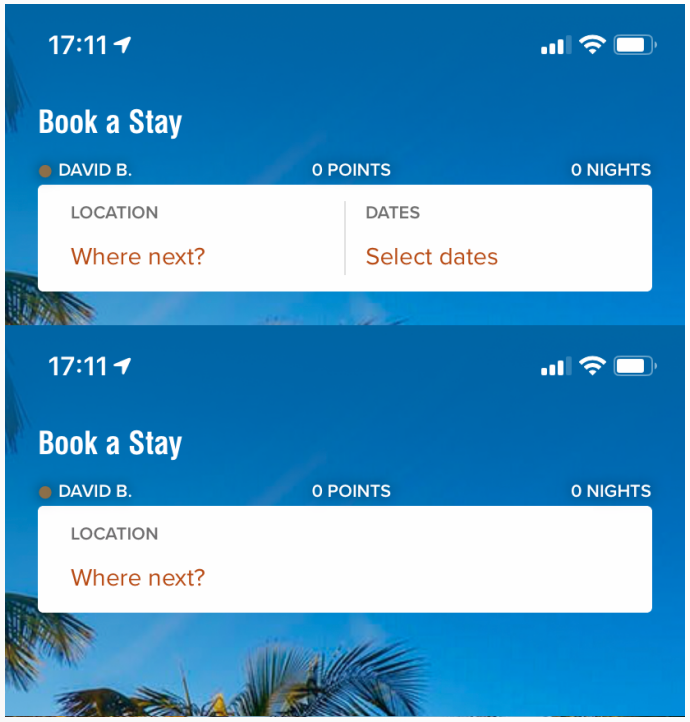


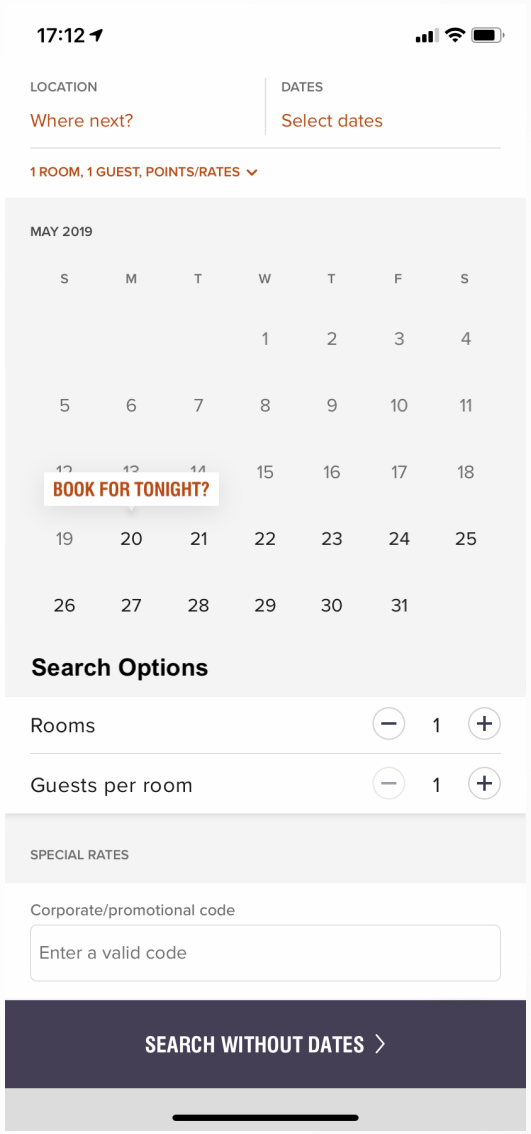
SOLUTION – Booking Steps Enforcement

- The current home page has two options to allow the user to choose Location or Date to start searching. The issue here is that the next page tries to assume that Date is the last option to be chosen and the UI suffers when the order is not followed. Also, forcing the user to follow a flow can help allow controlled date picking and other useful features that can only be used by maintaining a flow.
- Proposed is to use a wizard walkthrough for searching. First choose Location, then choose Dates, on dates page support accessing the other options without the need of opening a new page for more advanced search.
- This wizard approach would allow the user to easily follow the navigation of the app from step to step and understand the direction for going back easier.
- The search options are collapsed in an implied dropdown style area. However, this actually opens a new page. Including the basic options like number of rooms and guests (maybe also corporate code) could be added to the date with an option to expand it for the other rate discounts.

SOLUTION – Booking Steps Enforcement

- Merging the search box into one field and expanding the text to include something like “Where to next?” or some other marketing word on traveling within the Marriott collection.

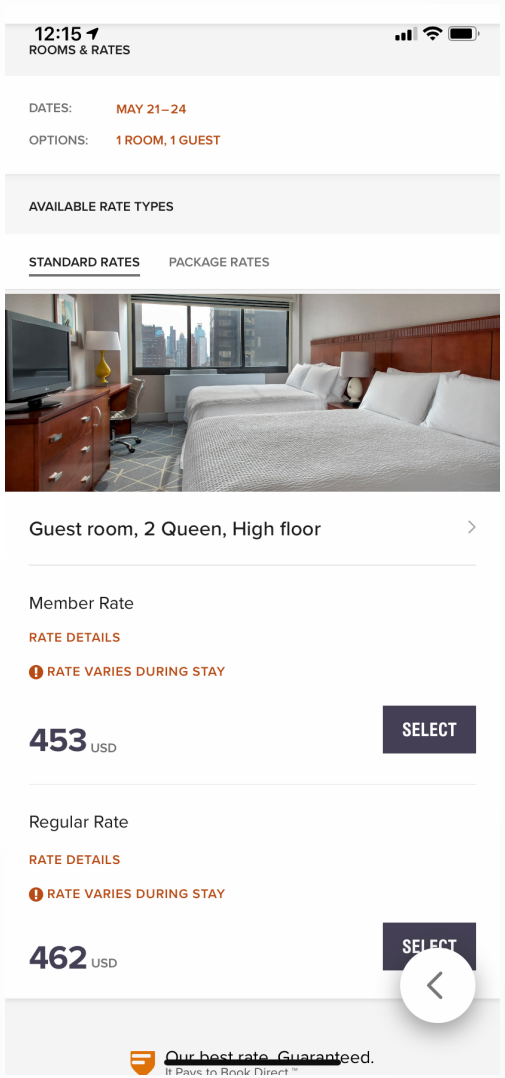


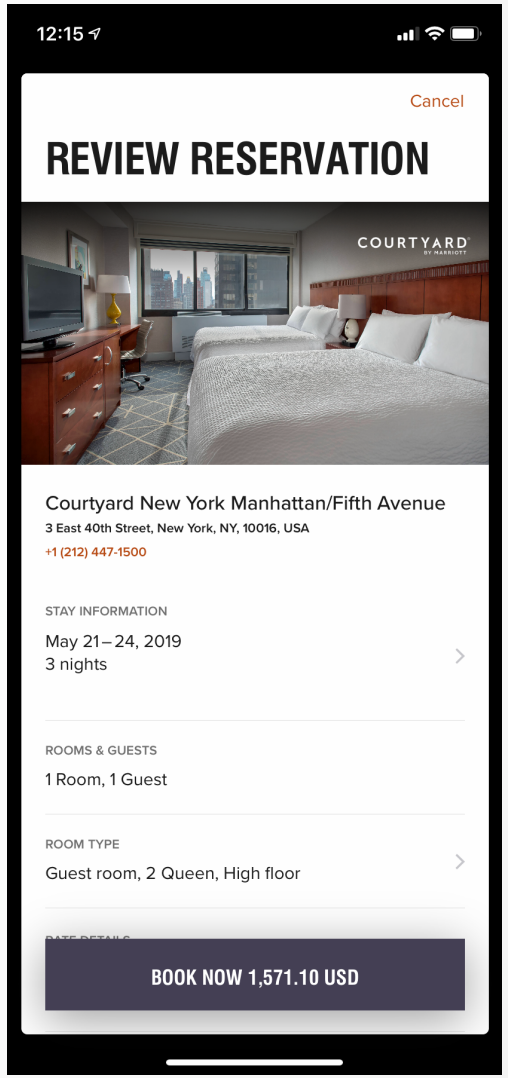


- Including the most important search options on the same page with the calendar can help users quickly set number of guests and rooms without opening a new page or taking the default options. This is important since some of these properties charge more for extra people and getting the correct price without having to alter search and reload is important.

PROBLEM – Confusing Back/Cancel usage

- The cancel button is used on a few options or pages that are brought into view from actions on other pages. However, other setting pages use the back button at the bottom. This mismatch leads to confusion. Also, the back button on some option changes takes you back to the wrong page; since it was brought up as an option change later in the app and the page provides no other way to cancel changing. Consistent paging navigation is important to avoid confusing the user. If the back flow was standardized across the application, it would improve user interaction and avoid confusion.



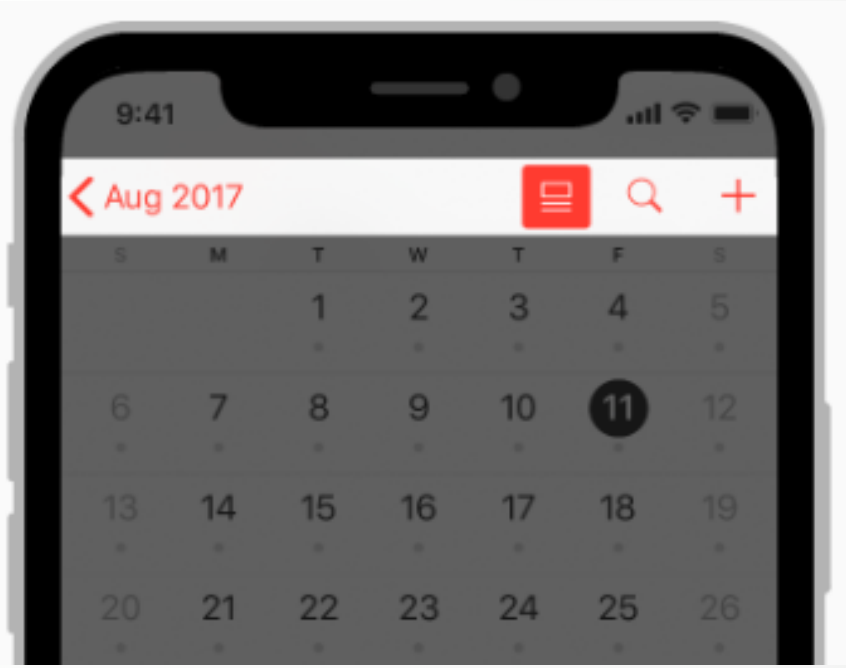


SOLUTION – Confusing Back/Cancel usage

- The mixed use of the back button as a floating circle and the cancel button in the top right introduce a mismatch in navigation and confusing interface when switching screens. The proposed solution would be to use standard ”Navigation Bars” on iOS. This would allow for a flow to be followed easily and to show the prior screen as well as the current screen. For example. When booking, the user would choose a location then date. Yielding the iOS Navigation bar to be

“< Location Choose date”

- All operations in this app can be seen as using a flow that can be followed (as seen in the top level navigation case), therefore this linear flow lends itself nicely to the use of the navigation bar.



https://developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/ios/bars/navigation-bars/

Conclusion

- **Trying new things**

  Overall the new app is sleek and modern and works well. Finding stuff initially is confusing and once the layout and flow of the app is understood it is easy to use. The new circle navigation system is interesting and most likely was used to try and differentiate itself from other booking apps and travel rewards. However, the final result may be confusing for some and sometimes ensuring customers can get what the need and checkout is important to ensure conversion into paying customers.

- **Design direction**

  The new design direction of Marriott and its brands is being modernized and this new application shows that. The color scheme and font choices are beautiful and well used. It is exciting to see what Marriott will have in store as it continues its growth and rebranding.